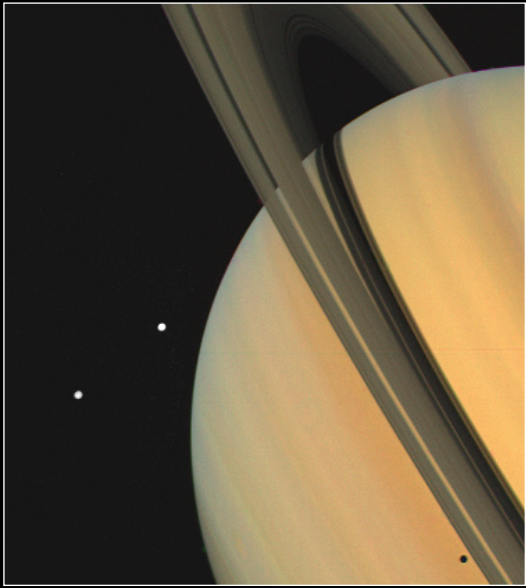


Saturn

Pale-yellow Saturn is the most distinctive planet due to its impressive ring system. It is second in size to Jupiter. Like Jupiter, its visible surface is its outer atmosphere, and it has a large family of moons. Saturn is also the most distant planet that is normally visible to the naked eye.

■ FEATURES

Saturn is made mainly of hydrogen and helium. They form the planet's gaseous outer layer, but inside, as the temperature and pressure increase with depth, the hydrogen and helium change state. Below the atmosphere they act like a liquid and, deeper still, like a liquid metal. A core of rock and ice is at the planet's center. The top



Saturn and its moons

Saturn dwarfs two of its largest moons, Tethys (top) and Dione (below). Shadows cast by Tethys and the main rings are seen on the planet's globe. The limb of the planet is also visible through the Cassini division separating the A and B rings.

Ringed world

Saturn's rings reflect sunlight well, making them and the planet easy to see. But those rings we readily see (shown here) are only part of the system; much fainter rings extend to about four times as far from the planet. Saturn is tilted relative to its orbit, so as it travels, first one hemisphere, then the other, is tilted sunward. This gives Saturn seasons and offers a changing view from Earth.

PLANET DATA

DIAMETER	74,897 miles (120,536 km)
AVERAGE DISTANCE FROM SUN	886.56 million miles (1.43 billion km)
ORBITAL PERIOD	29.5 Earth years
ROTATION PERIOD	10.7 hours
CLOUD-TOP TEMPERATURE	-292°F (-180°C)
NUMBER OF MOONS	56